CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

INTERIOR DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

AI can render a dream kitchen in four seconds — somebody still has to make it fit the budget, the building and the humans.

★ TL;DR — Around $75K median for credentialed design work built over 1–2 years of study and practice. The catch: clients buy taste, but they keep designers who can run budgets, trades and timelines. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

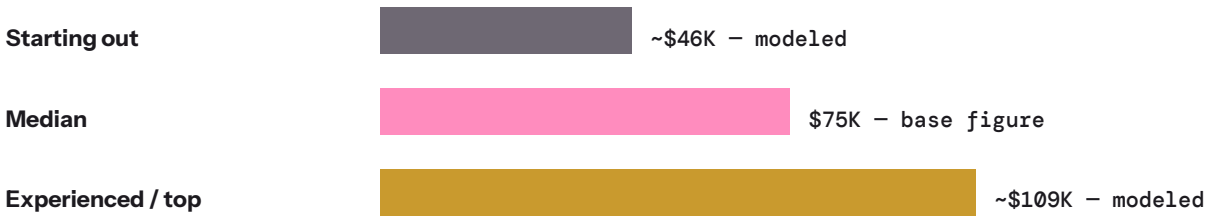
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Why it works: renovations are expensive and mistakes are worse — people pay to get rooms right once.
- Where it bites: the job is 30% design and 70% project management, purchasing and problem-solving.
- The AI angle: AI ate the moodboard layer; measurement, sourcing, site reality and client trust stayed human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Interior Designer is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A INTERIOR DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Read how clients live, then plan layouts, lighting and storage around it
- ✓ Specify furniture, finishes and fixtures within a real budget
- ✓ Coordinate contractors, deliveries and installs on site
- ✓ Present concepts, revise, and defend choices with reasons

Think: an architect of daily life crossed with a general contractor's conscience.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Rendering, moodboards and space-plan drafts are generated instantly now. Sourcing software compares prices and stock across suppliers automatically.	Site reality is the moat: walls that are not square, clients who change their minds, trades who need managing, and taste that reads a room in person. Delivery is a human sport.

⚠ **Pretty portfolios do not retain clients — budgets blown and timelines slipped do the firing. The credential path filters for exactly that discipline.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Creative work with serious budgets ✓ Rooms transform completely under your direction ✓ Mix of studio, site and client time	✗ Client revisions and decision paralysis ✗ Delivery disasters become your phone calls ✗ Evenings spent on drawings and orders

Good fit? You have taste and logistics in the same brain — you can source a sofa and run a spreadsheet about it.
Bad fit? You only want the fun visual part and wilt at budgets, trades and follow-ups.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — DESIGN STUDIO ASSISTANT	DOOR B — DECORATING-FIRST SOLO
Join a working studio: samples library, orders, site visits, drawings. You learn the business from inside real projects while building toward your credential — and studios promote assistants they trust with clients.	Start with styling, color and furnishing projects that need taste more than construction documents. Smaller scope, faster portfolio — then grow toward full renovations as your credential and trade network mature.

Smart move: Build a contractor bench you trust. Designers are rehired for painless projects, and painless is spelled 'reliable trades'.

Where you land after: Senior designer in a studio, your own residential practice, or a design-build partnership with a contractor.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
TRAIN THE	START THE	GET INSIDE	RUN SMALL	BUILD YOUR	FULL PROJECTS,

STEP 1 — Train the eye and the tools

FREE-$ · MONTHS 1-2

- Space planning, color, materials and lighting fundamentals
- Learn a real drafting/design tool — renders are table stakes now

STEP 2 — Start the credential path

MONTHS 1-6

- Map the certificate or qualification route you will complete
- Structured study separates designers from decorators in pay

STEP 3 — Get inside a studio

PAID · MONTHS 2-6

- Assistant or junior role: orders, samples, site days
- Watch budgets being built — copy that discipline

STEP 4 — Run small rooms solo

MONTHS 4-9

- One-room projects end to end for your portfolio
- Photograph everything professionally

STEP 5 — Build your trade network

MONTHS 6-12

- Contractors, workrooms, installers you can rely on
- Your vendor bench is your delivery guarantee

STEP 6 — Full projects, credential done

YEAR 1-2

- Kitchens, baths and whole-home scopes with supervision fading
- Credential complete: charge like the professional you now are

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

 Today: learn the difference between decorating and design — and which one you are training for.

□ Days 1–30: start fundamentals and a design tool; map your credential route.

□ Days 31–60: assist in a studio or take a first small room for a client.

□ Days 61–90: run one room end to end — budget, orders, install, photos.

□ Day 90: in the pipeline — the 1–2 year build is study plus projects, in that order, together.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ TASTE GETS HIRED. DELIVERY GETS REHIRED. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.